

version of the aircraft. In all, Douglas produced almost 30,000 aircraft between 1941 and 1945. In addition to expanding the output of aircraft manufacturers, the Americans turned automobile factories to aircraft production.

The result of rapid expansion might have been a sharp drop in quality, since large numbers of previously untrained workers had to be taken on. But the design of aircraft was intelligently modified to facilitate mass production and reduce the need for special skills in the workforce. The achievement of America's wartime aircraft industry did not come automatically from the United States being the world's leading industrial power. It was a feat of organization and applied intelligence that earned the success it deserved.

Although in retrospect the entry of the United States into the war in December 1941 doomed both Germany and Japan to eventual defeat, it took a long time to bring productivity and manpower to bear on the battlefield. The Americans and their Allies had to follow an arduous learning curve before their use of air power could match that of the Germans. In general, the Allies succeeded in sharply improving the performance of their aircraft and the training and experience of their pilots, while their enemies lost experienced pilots they could not adequately replace and often had to continue fighting in much the same aircraft with which they had started the war. In the spirit of "anything you can do, we can do better," the Allies learned to match and surpass the Germans in such areas as close air support and interdiction, and mount even bolder airborne offensives.

BUILDING FOR VICTORY

Over 18,000 four-engined Consolidated B-24 Liberator bombers rolled out of American factories during the war – an average of more than 10 a day. The ability to make aircraft in such unprecedented numbers was highly advantageous in terms of air superiority over enemies incapable of gearing up on the same scale.

BURMESE AIRDROP

GEORGE MACDONALD FRASER, a Scottish soldier at Meiktila in the Burmese jungle in 1944, had a ground-up view of a supply drop by Douglas C-47s:

"The first of the big Dakotas was droning in, circling the drop zone just above our heads, the Sikh unloaders visible in its open doorway. Behind came the other planes, following the slow circle, banking slightly while the Sikhs thrust out the big bales. It was a spectacular sight, the aircraft glittering in the sunlight, the bales falling in a continuous shower... Most of the great canvas bundles fell in what was called 'free drop,' hitting the paddy with resounding thumps and clouds of dust..."

"I saw one misdirected bale come streaking down to hit a jeep on the edge of the zone; it struck fair and square on the bonnet, flattening the vehicle in a tangled wreck..."

AERIAL LIFELINE

Allied troops fighting the Japanese in the jungles of Burma in 1944 were kept supplied by airdrops. Transport aircraft operated with impunity as the Japanese air force had been chased from the skies.

War in Asia

One aspect of the widening war was the need for airmen and ground crews to operate in the world's most inhospitable terrains and climates. It was in the Sahara that the Allies learned the effective use of air power against ground forces during their battles against the Afrika Korps in 1942–43. Here, flying conditions were usually good, but keeping aircraft engines free of clogging sand was another matter and taxed the ingenuity of technicians.

The Burma-China theater was more demanding still, becoming the site for some of the epics of World War II air combat. There, operating first out of Rangoon and then southern China, the Curtiss P-40s of Claire Chennault's truculently independent American Volunteer Group – better known as the Flying Tigers – inflicted heavy losses on numerically superior Japanese air forces in 1941–42. There also the remarkable guerrilla operations of General Orde Wingate's Chindit long-range penetration force were carried out in the Japanese-occupied Burmese jungle. Set up under Colonel Philip Cochran, the American Air Commando Group supported Wingate's imaginative forays with an array of aircraft, from gliders and C-47 transports to North American P-51 Mustang fighters and even a few early Sikorsky helicopters.

In their boldest operation, in March 1944, 67 of Cochran's Dakotas towed gliders carrying Chindit soldiers and American engineers, plus bulldozers and other heavy equipment, into

Burma, releasing them to fly down to jungle clearings. There they built landing strips so that transport aircraft could return the following night, landing troop reinforcements, artillery, jeeps, and more than a thousand mules. It did not work smoothly – half of the first wave of gliders was lost – but it did allow Wingate to, in his own words, "insert himself in the guts of the enemy."

FLYING SHARK

This distinctive sharkmouth decoration was adopted by 112 Squadron of Britain's Royal Air Force (RAF) in North Africa in the second half of 1941.

